that public messaging resonated with populist narratives, particularly during high-profile summits.[43]

Behind the scenes, NATO relied on quiet diplomacy to navigate Trump's unpredictability. Stoltenberg engaged in private negotiations with Trump, allowing him to voice public criticisms while maintaining cooperation in practice (Dijkstra et al. 2022). These back-channel discussions fostered a working relationship between the NATO chief and Trump, enabling Stoltenberg to manage Trump's demands without alienating him (Dijkstra et al. 2022). By accommodating Trump's need to appear as a tough negotiator, NATO retained US participation and avoided outright confrontation.[44]

In areas where appeasement was unfeasible, NATO resorted to sidelining Trump's influence, particularly on matters related to Russia. While Trump advocated for closer ties with Moscow, most NATO members vehemently opposed this stance. Rather than directly challenging Trump, NATO leaders worked around him by engaging US institutions and individuals more aligned with NATO's traditional posture, such as the State Department, the Pentagon, and Congress (Schuette 2023). Figures like Defense Secretary James Mattis served as crucial intermediaries in maintaining continuity within the alliance. Additionally, NATO strategically kept Russia off the agenda during key meetings, preemptively securing agreements on declarations to limit Trump's ability to disrupt proceedings (Schuette 2023).

These strategies proved effective in many respects. Trump's public critiques of NATO persisted, but the United States remained engaged in the alliance throughout his first term. Defense spending among NATO members increased incrementally, and Trump publicly claimed victory, boasting during his 2019 State of the Union address that his leadership had secured billions in commitments from allies.[45] Despite Trump's initial reluctance, the United States continued to support NATO-led operations and maneuvers targeting Russian aggression.

However, appeasement and tactical maneuvering did not completely mollify Trump. On the campaign trail for the 2024 election, he revisited familiar criticisms of NATO, calling the alliance underfunded and questioning its value to the United States.[46] His rhetoric reignited concerns about a potential US withdrawal, underscoring the fragility of the alliance's relationship with populist leaders.[47] While NATO successfully managed Trump's first presidency without losing the United States as a member, his